

The Battle

Halo 3's controls aren't too complex, so the game doesn't offer you much training before it throws you into the action. Action, mind you, that starts early into the game, and literally doesn't stop—sure, you'll get time to breathe a little every once in a while, but your heart rate doesn't drop to normal till you rip yourself away from your console. You're constantly beset by Covenant forces in large numbers, so skirmishes are long and intense.

Most of the time, you'll be battling Brutes—the more elaborate his armour, the higher he is ranked, and thus more dangerous. The way they tend to charge at you is very worrying—especially in the beginning—and if they get too close, can kill you with considerable, well, brutality. Their edge wears off as you get used to dealing with them, but they're always fun to fight. Soon, you'll be pitting yourself against the Covenant's vehicles, including the jaw-droppingly massive Scarab Tank.

There are many ways to approach the same situation, so you don't get that I'm-hitting-my-head-against-a-brick-wall feeling every time you die (which tends to happen a lot at some points) and spawn to try again. You're also only allowed only two weapons at a time, so your choice also affects the approach you take in battle. And speaking of weapons...

You're not fighting alone for a large part of the game—your fellow soldiers are not only too happy to help you dispose of enemies, but you can also ask them for their weapons if you get bored with yours.

Finally, there are the vehicles—the faithful Warthog returns, as do many of the old favourites, and you now get to take command of the quad-bike-like Mongoose. You can also take command of enemy vehicles, including the Brute Chopper—a rather ungainly motorcycle with a razor-like front wheel and powerful cannon. You can also sit in the back of a vehicle if you'd rather shoot than drive, but your fellow soldiers are the worst bunch of Sunday drivers I've ever seen.

The Verdict

The thing that hits you about *Halo 3* is the scale—nearly every scenario finds you in a super-massive environment. The visuals are as stunning as we've come to expect from Xbox 360 games, with a few subtle niceties like the real-time reflections on Master Chief's visor and self-shadows on objects.

I've voiced my dislike for the console-FPS combination before, but surprisingly, *Halo 3* felt just right. I only had trouble with the flying drones, but luckily I had comrades to dispose of them while I hid in a corner. There are



The Tools

Most of *Halo 3*'s weapons are standard FPS fare—assault rifles (making a comeback from the first game), sub-machine guns, shotguns, sniper rifles, and their Covenant counterparts. Also like in other FPSes, you can man turrets to deal with more enemies, or just more pesky ones. Even better—and this is my favourite part—you can rip the guns off the turrets and lug them around, wreaking general havoc. You don't go as fast, but when you're mowing down battalions of Brutes and laughing evilly, who cares?

elements of the game that reminded me of *Half-life 2*: the Breen-like appearances of holograms of the Prophet of Truth, the fact that you're leading lesser humans into battle against the aliens that threaten humanity and that every time there's a huge boss coming up, you'll find the heavy-duty weaponry required easily accessible.

But that doesn't really matter—what truly matters in a game is how much fun it is. *Halo 3* is fun—every controller-gripping, nature's-call-holding, meal-skipping hour of it.

nimish_chandiramani@thinkdigit.com